

At the End of Every Why

A metaphysical ascent to the God who is love

A patristic, Thomistic, and mystical study

From received existence, through the uncreated source of being,
to the mystery disclosed in the Word and the Spirit

Contents

1	When the Familiar World Ceases to Explain Itself	1
2	Not the First Domino	1
3	The One Who Does Not Receive	3
4	Nearer Than Nearness	4
5	The Darkness of Excess	5
6	Reason at the Threshold	6
7	The Word and Love	7
8	Love Gives Being	8
9	The Last Word	9
A	Scope, Method, and Qualifications	11
B	References	12
C	Generation Metadata	13

1 When the Familiar World Ceases to Explain Itself

There is a thought that can make an ordinary room suddenly strange. The table stands. Light gathers on a wall. A hand moves across a page. Nothing spectacular has happened, and yet the mind notices what habit usually conceals: *each of these things is, and none of them contains within itself the sufficient reason why it is at all.*

The wood explains why the table bears weight. The lamp explains the patch of light. Muscles and nerves explain the movement of the hand. These are true explanations, and the ascent must not erase them. But each answer opens beneath itself. Why does this matter possess these powers? Why are those powers actual here and now? Why is there a lamp, a body, a world in which causes can act—rather than nothing?

Follow the question without allowing one unexplained receiver to hide behind another. The mind passes from event to condition, from condition to cause, from cause to the actuality by which it can cause. At first the movement feels like an investigation. Then its scale changes. Everything one can point to says, by the very limits of what it is: *I have not given being to myself.*

That is the beginning of metaphysical vertigo. The world remains solid under the feet, yet it has ceased to be self-grounding. Every finite thing is suspended over no physical abyss; it is suspended over its own inability to account for the act by which it is real. The question is no longer only whether God exists. It is whether anything else possesses existence in the same unreceived way.

Governing thesis

The regress from changing, caused, and participated being does not terminate in the oldest event or the largest member of the universe. In the Thomistic synthesis, it reaches one uncaused source: pure act, subsistent being itself, from whom every creature receives and in whom every creature is continuously held. Natural reason can reach this threshold, but it cannot deduce the Trinity. Revelation discloses that the one Creator is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, and that the Word through whom all things are made unveils the Creator's innermost mystery: "God is love" (1 John 4:8, 16).

This ascent therefore has two movements that must neither be separated nor confused. Metaphysics asks what creatures require if they are really creatures. Faith receives what the uncreated One has freely made known of himself. The first movement prevents devotion from dissolving into sentiment. The second prevents the first Cause from being mistaken for an anonymous force.

The Fathers knew both movements. They reasoned from the beauty, mutability, and dependence of the world; they also trembled before the God whom no concept contains. Aquinas gave the ascent an exact grammar of act and potency, essence and existence, cause and participation. The mystics refused to let exactness become possession. They carried the intellect to the place where true knowledge becomes wonder, and wonder becomes desire.

The aim here is not to simulate a private revelation or manufacture an emotion. It is to look steadily enough at being that wonder may arise on its own: astonishment before a world wholly given, reverent fear before the One who cannot fail to be, and desire for the mystery beyond the reach of the ascent.

2 Not the First Domino

2.1 Backward in time is not yet metaphysically deep

The imagination hears "first cause" and supplies a picture: an unimaginably remote beginning, a divine hand touching the first domino, the universe then traveling away under its own momentum. That picture can gesture toward a temporal beginning, which Christian faith confesses. It does not yet reach what Aquinas means by a cause that is first in the order of being.

For Aquinas, reason alone does not demonstrate that the world had a first instant. He argues that even a world with no temporal beginning—considered only as a philosophical hypothesis—would still be created, because "created" means receiving being from another, not merely beginning after a stretch of empty time (ST I, q. 46, a. 2). A beginning answers *when*. Creation reaches the more radical question: *from what does the whole actuality of the creature come?*

Earlier events may explain later ones through powers they already possess. A dead ancestor need not remain present for a descendant to act. This is an accidentally ordered series: once generated, the later cause has a real created power of its own. Metaphysical regress becomes decisive when the power exercised by an intermediate is derivative in the very order under consideration. A mirror truly reflects, but it does not illuminate by being merely a mirror. A procession of mirrors may carry light from one to another; multiplying reflections, even without a last countable member, does not make reflected light underived.

The analogy is limited, but the point is exact. Created causes are not unreal. Fire genuinely heats, parents genuinely beget, intellects genuinely understand, and wills genuinely choose. Yet in the act by which any of them is actual, each displays a dependence more intimate than succession. The question is not whether a creature acts, but why there is an acting creature with an actual power to exercise.

2.2 From potency to act

Change makes the structure visible. What is only potentially warm cannot, precisely insofar as it remains potential, make itself actually warm. When it becomes warm, potency has been reduced to act. That reduction requires what is already actual in the relevant respect (ST I, q. 2, a. 3).

The point is wider than motion through space. Growth, learning, chemical change, choice, and the exercise of causal power each require actuality under some aspect. If every cause in the relevant order had only borrowed power, none would account for the power being exercised. An endless deferral does not become an explanation merely by lacking a visible edge.

This is the force of an essentially ordered regress. Aquinas's first two "ways" begin not from the careless premise "everything has a cause" but from actualization and caused causal power. What is actualized cannot actualize itself in the same respect; what receives its causal power cannot be the ultimate source of that power. Explanation terminates only in a source that does not receive the actuality being explained.

What "first" means

"First" here does not mean earliest in a timeline, nearest to the beginning of the universe, or first among otherwise comparable objects. It means non-derivative in the order of actuality and being. The first Cause is not the first domino. If every domino vanished, God would not be left as a lonely domino. He is not a member of the series at all.

2.3 Why the regress cannot end in another creature

Suppose the mind names one more finite cause. However powerful, if it receives its actuality, the question remains. If its nature includes unrealized possibilities, acquired perfections, components that must be united, or an existence that it can fail to have, it is not the underived source the regress requires. Calling it "first" changes a label, not its metaphysical condition.

Taken together with Aquinas's ensuing arguments from immutability and simplicity, the underived first source is without passive potency altogether: not something waiting to become, acquire, assemble, or continue (ST I, q. 3, aa. 1–2). Aquinas calls this pure act. The phrase does not mean frantic activity or maximal energy. It means that in the first source there is no unrealized capacity and no received perfection. Nothing stands behind it to confer the actuality by which it causes.

Here the vertigo sharpens. The mind is accustomed to understanding one thing through another. But at the root, "another" must cease. Not because inquiry becomes lazy, and not because an arbitrary wall has been erected, but because an ultimate explanation cannot possess by dependence the very actuality it is invoked to explain. There must be One who does not become real, who is not kept real, and whose causal power is not on loan.

3 The One Who Does Not Receive

3.1 Not a being that happens to exist

Finite things do not exhaust existence. A human being exists humanly; an oak exists according to the bounded nature of an oak; an angel, in Thomistic theology, would exist immaterially yet still according to a received created nature. In each case the answer to *what is it?* does not by itself explain *that it is*. Its act of being is possessed under a limit.

Aquinas gives this distinction its most concentrated form. Where essence and existence are distinct, existence is caused; a thing cannot give itself the act by which it is available to act at all. The first efficient cause therefore cannot be a being whose existence is received. In God alone, essence is not one principle and existence another. God does not merely *have* being. He is his act of being (ST I, q. 3, a. 4; *De ente et essentia*, ch. 4).

The traditional formula is *ipsum esse subsistens*: subsistent being itself. It must be heard carefully. God is not “being in general,” a thin abstraction formed by noticing what creatures share. Nor is he a universal substance of which creatures are pieces, a cosmic field, or the sum total of everything. Common being is a concept predicable of many. Subsistent being is the one unreceived actuality from whom the many receive their diverse acts of existence (ST I, q. 4, a. 2; q. 44, a. 1).

This is why the regress does not discover a hidden object behind visible objects. It discovers that the source of every object is not an object in the creaturely sense. God and the world do not add up to two specimens within a larger inventory called reality. There is no larger field containing them both. The Creator–creature distinction is more radical: one is being without reception; every other reality has being by participation.

3.2 Without seams

Anything composed depends upon principles that account for its unity. Matter receives form. A whole requires its parts to be together. An accident modifies a subject. A member of a genus is specified and limited by what distinguishes it from other members. If the first source were composite in any of these ways, the unity and actuality of its components would still call for explanation.

Pure act is therefore simple—not easy, featureless, or impoverished, but without metaphysical seams. In God there is no composition of matter and form, essence and existence, substance and accident, genus and difference, or unrealized capacity and acquired act (ST I, q. 3). Wisdom, goodness, power, life, and love are not detachable properties fastened to a neutral divine core. They name from different creaturely angles the one infinite actuality that is God.

Divine simplicity does not shrink God into blankness. It means that every pure perfection found divided and limited in creatures pre-exists in the first source without division or limit. Because God is subsistent being, no perfection of being is absent from him; what is dispersed among creatures is one in its uncreated cause (ST I, q. 4, a. 2). The One is not less than the many. The many are fragmentary likenesses of the fullness they cannot contain.

3.3 Why there can be only one

Two numerically distinct divine essences or independent first sources would have to differ. One would possess something the other lacked, or each would instantiate a common nature under some differentiating condition. Either way, at least one would be limited by received or composite actuality. But subsistent being is not received into a limiting nature, and pure act lacks no perfection of being. Aquinas therefore argues from simplicity and infinite perfection that there cannot be several gods. This establishes unity of divine essence; it does not exclude the revealed distinction of Persons by subsistent relations of origin (ST I, q. 11, a. 3; q. 29, a. 4).

The unity reached here is not the number one set beside the number two. It is the indivisibility of the unconditioned source. God is not one because competitors happen not to exist. He is one because the actuality that is wholly unreceived and unrestricted cannot be multiplied by receivers, matter, differences, or limits (ST I, q. 11, a. 4).

Christian tradition hears a profound consonance between this metaphysical judgment and the name revealed to Moses: “I AM” (Exod 3:14). The scriptural name is not a scholastic formula smuggled into ancient Hebrew, and the proof does not rest on a translation of one verse. Yet Aquinas and the wider tradition rightly receive the name as luminous:

creatures can say “I am this” or “I am now”; the One without origin says simply that he is (ST I, q. 13, a. 11; CCC 203–213).

Try to let the negations have their weight. No cause behind him. No material beneath him. No possibility waiting within him. No future in which he becomes more fully himself. No larger reality against which he is measured. No second source dividing the field. The mind has traced every dependent “because” to the One in whom essence and existence are not two.

At that point one does not yet comprehend God. One has learned why comprehension must fail. There is nowhere outside the source of being from which to take his measure.

4 Nearer Than Nearness

4.1 Creation has no material underneath it

Human making begins with something: stone, sound, language, a field of forces, an inherited world. Creation in the strict sense does not. To create *ex nihilo* is not to shape a mysterious substance called “nothing.” It is to cause the whole being of the creature without presupposing matter, subject, place, or time as an independent partner (ST I, q. 45, aa. 1–3).

This is why creation is not merely a very great change. Change presupposes a subject that becomes otherwise. In creation there is no prior creature undergoing the transition from nonbeing to being. There is only the creature as wholly caused, with everything by which it is something rather than nothing received from the universal cause. Even time belongs on the side of the gift.

St. Athanasius begins his account of the Incarnation here. Against schemes in which the world emerges from pre-existent matter or from another creator, he confesses that the good God made the universe from nothing through his Word. The same Word who gives existence is the one who enters creation to rescue it from corruption (*On the Incarnation* 3–5). Creation and redemption already lean toward one another: the source of being is not indifferent to what he has freely called forth.

“Freely” is essential. The world is not a necessary spill from the divine substance, and God does not create to complete a lack. He necessarily loves his own infinite goodness; he does not need a finite reflection in order to be good. Creatures are willed without compulsion, not because the Creator is lonely, improved, or enlarged by them (ST I, q. 19, aa. 2–4; Vatican I, *Dei Filius*, ch. 1).

4.2 The gift is being given now

Creation’s radical character does not recede with the age of the universe. If God caused only an initial state and then withdrew, creatures would need to acquire independent possession of the act of being. But what has existence by participation never turns that reception into existence by essence. The dependence belongs to what the creature is, not merely to how long ago it began.

Aquinas therefore treats conservation as the continuation of the creative giving of being. It is not a repeated divine decision or a repair performed from moment to moment. God’s one eternal act has a temporal effect: for as long as a creature exists, its act of existence remains caused. Aquinas compares this to light remaining in air while illumination continues, while warning that the divine giving itself implies neither motion nor succession in God (ST I, q. 104, a. 1).

The world is not a machine abandoned by its maker. Nor is it a stage on which God occasionally appears. The Creator is present to every creature as the cause of its most intimate actuality. Being is deeper in a thing than any color, location, feeling, memory, or relation; without it none of these can be actual. Because God causes that act, Aquinas says God is in all things “most intimately”—not as a part of their essence or an accident within them, but as the agent giving them being (ST I, q. 8, a. 1).

Augustine found language for the paradox: God is *interior intimo meo et superior summo meo*—more inward than what is innermost in me and higher than what is highest in me (*Confessions* III.6.11). Divine transcendence and divine intimacy do not compete. Precisely because God is not one being at a distance from another, spatial separation

does not mediate his causal presence. He is beyond every creature by nature and present at the root of its actuality as sustaining cause.

4.3 Participation without absorption

Aquinas uses participation to name this received likeness. Iron made hot by fire is genuinely hot, but it receives heat rather than possessing it as source. The analogy is limited: fire too is a creature whose being is received. Yet in the relevant order it shows how a perfection can truly belong to a participant without making that participant its underived source. So every creature genuinely exists and is genuinely good, but under a bounded mode it does not originate. What belongs to God by essence is reflected in creatures by participation (ST I, q. 44, a. 1).

The analogy protects two truths. Against pantheism, the creature is not a piece, mode, or dilution of God. Creation produces a reality really distinct from its cause. Against deism, that distinction is not independence. The creature is most itself when it receives; dependence upon the Creator is not an injury later imposed on its freedom but the condition under which there is a creature capable of freedom at all.

Look again at the hand, the wall, the small pool of light. Their familiarity has returned, but it has changed. Each is poised between nothing and the One who is, not precariously as though divine attention might wander, but gratuitously: nothing in the creature makes the gift owed. Its existence is a fact inside the world and, at the same time, a relation to the uncreated source no instrument can measure.

The metaphysical regress has therefore turned inward. The source is not only “back there” at the end of reasoning. The act by which the reader now exists is already the place where the dependence is enacted. Beneath thought, beneath breath, beneath the capacity to ask why, there is the silent, continuous gift: *you do not have being from yourself. At this instant, you are being given to be.*

5 The Darkness of Excess

The success of the ascent creates its own danger. The intellect has concluded something true: there is one unreceived source, pure act and subsistent being, simple, unbounded, and intimately causal to all that is. It may now mistake true predication for possession. It may turn “God” into a concept small enough to survey.

The patristic and mystical tradition refuses that reduction. St. Gregory Nazianzen distinguishes conviction that God is from comprehension of what God is. Created effects can lead the mind to their efficient and sustaining cause, yet the divine nature remains beyond enclosure by a created intellect (*Oration* 28.4–6). Elsewhere he gathers biblical and philosophical language into the image of a limitless “Sea of Being,” glimpsed only partially, drawing the mind by what it reveals and awakening wonder by what exceeds it (*Oration* 45.3).

This is not an embarrassment added after the proof. It follows from the proof. If the divine essence were exhaustively comprehensible by a finite intellect, the unlimited would be contained by the limited. If God belonged to a genus, stood under principles more universal than himself, or possessed existence according to a limited mode, the regress would not have reached its source. The same reasoning that affirms God therefore requires the mind to deny of him every creaturely limitation.

Aquinas announces this discipline at the entrance to his treatment of the divine essence. Since we cannot know what God is in himself by our natural power, he says, we proceed chiefly by learning how God is not: not bodily, not composed, not mutable, not contained in a genus (ST I, q. 3, prologue). Negation does not erase the positive knowledge gained from effects. It purifies that knowledge of the mode in which perfections belong to creatures.

God is good, but not as one good object among others. God is wise, but not by receiving truths, reasoning toward conclusions, or adding knowledge. God is present, but not by occupying coordinates. God is one, but not as one counted unit. Analogical language is neither literal in an identical creaturely sense nor merely decorative. It speaks truly because effects resemble their cause; it fails to contain because the mode of every divine perfection infinitely exceeds the mode from which the creaturely word was learned (ST I, q. 13, aa. 4–5).

5.1 The luminous night

The anonymous late-fifth- or early-sixth-century theologian known as Pseudo-Dionysius makes this purification into an ascent. The mind moves through sensible things and intelligible names, affirming every perfection of the universal cause; then it relinquishes the thought that even its highest affirmation captures God as he is. In the *Mystical Theology*, Moses enters the darkness beyond seeing and being seen. The darkness signifies neither evil nor divine absence. It is the dazzling failure of finite sight before an excess of light (*Mystical Theology* I.1–3; II.1).

This “unknowing” is not ignorance enthroned, a rejection of doctrine, or a technique for producing altered consciousness. Dionysian negation depends upon the affirmations it transcends. One must first know that God is cause, good, wise, living, and beyond creation before understanding why no creaturely form of those names circumscribes him. Silence is not the rival of truth. It is truth’s reverence before the One it cannot turn into an object.

St. Augustine narrates the existential form of the ascent. Turning inward, he passes beyond mutable bodily images and even beyond the mutable mind to an unchangeable Light above it—above because it made him, while he is below because he was made (*Confessions* VII.10.16–11.17). He does not report calm mastery. The vision is flash-like; the mind knows, loves, trembles, and cannot remain by its own strength. In Book XI he holds together dread before the divine unlikeness and burning desire awakened by the likeness God has impressed upon the creature (XI.9.11).

The experience gives metaphysics a human temperature. To discover the uncreated source is not to stand above a successful argument. It is to discover that the power by which one argues, the truth one recognizes, and the being of the one who recognizes it are all received—while the One dimly known is not received at all.

Apophatic realism

The mind does not enter darkness because there is nothing to know. It enters because the reality known exceeds every finite manner of knowing. The right response is neither agnosticism nor conceptual possession, but a disciplined union of affirmation, negation, wonder, and desire.

At the summit of natural ascent, then, there is a strange conjunction: greater certainty that God is, greater inability to imagine what God is, greater intimacy of causal presence, and greater transcendence of essence. The mind has reached the shore of its natural power. It can know that the sea is there. It cannot, by staring harder at the water, discover the secret of the divine life.

6 Reason at the Threshold

The boundary must be stated without haze. Natural reason can ascend from creatures to one Creator and can predicate of him, analogically, intellect, will, goodness, and love. Aquinas argues that love is in God because love is the first movement of will toward good, while the divine will is identical in reality with the simple divine essence (ST I, q. 20, a. 1). But this does not disclose the distinction of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Aquinas is emphatic: the Trinity of divine Persons cannot be demonstrated by natural reason. Creatures lead the mind to what belongs to God as their one creative principle; creative power is common to the whole Trinity and does not of itself reveal the personal relations (ST I, q. 32, a. 1). Arguments that make companionship necessary to divine goodness fail twice. They weaken faith by presenting a noncompelling inference as proof, and they imagine that infinite goodness needs another in order to be complete.

The hinge of the article

Metaphysics reaches the one uncreated source of all being. It does not derive the Trinity, and it does not by itself reach the full Johannine confession “God is love.” At this threshold the mode of knowing changes: reason does not surrender its integrity, but listens to what God freely reveals.

St. Augustine’s famous triad of lover, beloved, and love must remain on the right side of this boundary. In *De Trinitate* VIII, Augustine moves through created goods toward Good itself and through true love of the brother toward the God whom the First Letter of John names Love. He then notices three terms in love: one who loves, what is loved, and love. Yet he immediately treats this as a place from which to continue seeking, not as a psychological container for God or a proof that compels the doctrine of the Trinity (VIII.3.4–5; VIII.7.10–10.14).

That restraint makes the analogy more fruitful. Revelation can teach the mind to recognize vestiges it could not correctly interpret in advance. Once God has named himself Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, created word and love can become distant likenesses of eternal processions. Without revelation, they cannot tell us that the one essence subsists in three Persons. They can prepare wonder; they cannot produce the mystery.

6.1 The Johannine threshold

The confession toward which this ascent is drawn is Johannine, though its two halves lie across the Gospel and the First Letter. “God is love” occurs twice in 1 John, at 4:8 and 4:16. The Gospel supplies the prologue to the confession: the Word is with God and is God; all things come to be through him; the Word becomes flesh and makes the unseen Father known (John 1:1–3, 14, 18). In Jesus’ final prayer, the Father loved the Son before the foundation of the world (John 17:24).

The letter then names the mystery within a history of self-gift. Love is from God. The Father sends the Son so that the world may have life through him. The Son is sent as expiation and Savior. The Spirit is given so that believers abide in God, confess the Son, and love one another. Only within that revealed, Trinitarian, and Paschal movement does John repeat the words: “God is love” (1 John 4:7–16).

The sentence is therefore not an abstract equation between God and whatever a culture happens to call love. It does not mean that love is a genus above God, that intense feeling is divine, or that truth and judgment dissolve into affirmation. The letter gives the words their grammar: initiative from the Father, manifestation in the Son’s mission and self-offering, indwelling through the Spirit, and a commanded participation made visible in love of the brother.

Reason arrives at the threshold with real knowledge and empty hands. The one source is not anonymous, but reason cannot compel him to speak. Revelation is not one more rung in the causal ladder. It is the free self-disclosure of the One whom the ladder could only know from effects.

And what he discloses is more astonishing than the mind’s highest unaided conclusion. Apart from every creature and without any increase from creation, God is eternally Father, Word, and Love.

7 The Word and Love

Christian revelation does not place three beings behind the one first Cause. It confesses one simple divine essence in three really distinct Persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The distinction is not made of parts, degrees, separate wills, or temporal stages. It is relation of origin within the undivided divine life. Everything that belongs to the divine essence—being, wisdom, goodness, power, will, and essential love—is wholly possessed by each Person, because each Person is the one God (Lateran IV, *Firmiter credimus*; CCC 202, 252–255).

The Son is not a first creature added to God. He is the eternal Word, begotten and not made. St. Athanasius built his defense of Nicene faith around this truth: if the Word through whom all things are made belonged among the things made, creation would still lack the uncreated Word by whom it comes to be. The Father is never without his proper Word and Wisdom (*Orations Against the Arians* I.14, 19; *On the Incarnation* 3).

Aquinas receives the patristic confession and gives it a metaphysical grammar. In an intellectual nature, an inward word proceeds as what is conceived in understanding. In the infinite simplicity of God, this procession is not a motion, an acquisition of knowledge, or the production of an accident. The divine Word is subsistent and eternal, one in essence with the Father from whom he is begotten (ST I, q. 27, aa. 1–2; q. 34, aa. 1–2).

Love gives the second analogy. What is known as good awakens love; in God, the procession according to will is no created affection added to the lover. Aquinas calls the Holy Spirit “Love” personally, as the Word is named personally of the Son. Essential love remains common to Father, Son, and Spirit; proceeding Love names the Spirit according to relation of origin (ST I, q. 27, aa. 3–4; q. 37, a. 1).

These analogies do not let the mind inspect the Trinity from above. “Word” and “Love” are analogical names schooled by revelation. They exclude change, ignorance, bodily generation, emotional need, and division; they help confess an order of origin without a before and after. The Father does not become Father. The Son does not begin to be. The Spirit is not a later bond introduced between previously separate subjects. Eternity has no childhood.

7.1 Love without need

Created love often begins in lack. The lover discovers a goodness not possessed, is moved by it, and reaches outward. Bodily emotion may accompany the movement; time may deepen or diminish it. None of this creaturely imperfection can simply be projected into God.

In God, love is pure act. God does not discover goodness outside himself, become attracted, or acquire communion. The Father, Son, and Spirit are not three incomplete selves who need relationship to become whole. Each is the one infinite divine essence; the Persons are really distinct by subsistent relations of origin within the one simple divine life.

This is why creation can be genuinely free. If God first became loving by creating, the creature would complete the Creator and the world would be necessary to divine fulfillment. But the Father loves the Son in the communion of the Holy Spirit without dependence upon anything made. Jesus' words in John 17:24 open this abyss: the Father's love for the Son is not one event within the history of the world. It is already eternal when there is no world to supply an audience.

"God is love" therefore says infinitely more than "God loves." It does not merely assign one admirable activity to a subject who could be otherwise. In the one simple essence, love is not an accident. The living God is the unreceived plenitude signified by the name—essentially the one charity of Father, Son, and Spirit, and personally, in Aquinas's careful usage, the Holy Spirit as proceeding Love.

Here the metaphysical and revealed movements meet without collapsing. Pure act means there is no needy potential waiting to be fulfilled. Trinity means the uncreated fullness subsists personally as Father, Son, and Spirit. Simplicity means Love is not one part of God. Creation means finite being is not divine substance. Revelation means these truths are not a portrait drawn from philosophical desire, but a confession governed by the Word made flesh and the Spirit given.

The first Cause is not behind Love, as though love required a deeper explanation. Nor is Love behind being, as though two principles competed for ultimacy. In the simple God, the One who is and the One who is Love are not two.

8 Love Gives Being

The ascent began with the creature's confession: I have not given being to myself. The Thomistic account of divine love, now read in the light of revelation, permits a stronger statement without turning creation into necessity: the creature exists because God freely wills its good.

Aquinas marks the difference between created and divine love. Human love ordinarily encounters or imagines goodness and is moved by it. The goodness of the beloved is not caused simply by being loved. God's will, however, is the cause of created being and every created perfection. To love is to will good to another; therefore God's love does not find an independently existing goodness that persuades him. It gives and sustains the goodness by which the creature is lovable. In Aquinas's compressed phrase, divine love "infuses and creates goodness in things" (ST I, q. 20, a. 2).

The Book of Wisdom supplies the scriptural resonance: God loves all things that exist, detests nothing he has made, and preserves what he has called into being (Wis 11:24–26). This is not because nonbeing exerted a claim or because the world forced a choice. The gratuitousness remains absolute. Love is not an explanation that makes creation necessary; it names the free willing of the creature's good by the One who needs nothing from it.

Every created perfection can now be read as gift without becoming a coded message whose details we confidently decipher. The existence of a sparrow, a distant galaxy, a difficult neighbor, or the person reading is not self-grounded. Each is known and willed in the one divine act. Not everything that happens within creation is morally good, and the mystery of evil requires distinctions this article cannot supply in full. But whatever positive actuality a creature possesses is not outside the creative love that causes being and goodness; evil as evil is privation, not a rival substance produced by another first principle.

8.1 The ascent is answered by a descent

Metaphysics climbs from effects toward their cause. The Gospel according to John announces the reverse movement: the Word through whom the world is made enters the world. The First Letter of John does not leave divine love at

the level of invisible causality. Love is manifested because the Father sends the only Son into the world that we might live through him; its measure is not our initiative but God's prior self-gift (1 John 4:9–10, 14).

The Cross therefore interprets the sentence “God is love.” It does not cause the Trinity to become loving. It manifests eternal divine charity in history; the missions of Son and Spirit express their eternal processions (ST I, q. 43, aa. 1–2). The one who suffers is truly the divine Son in the human nature he assumed; the divine nature does not become mutable or passible (CCC 468–469). Christian love is neither a cosmic emotion nor the romanticization of pain. It is the self-giving holiness by which God seeks the creature's true good at the cost borne in the flesh of the Word.

St. Athanasius sees creation and redemption united in the one Word. The Word who called humanity from nonbeing is the Word who assumes a body to renew the corrupted image and conquer death. Only the maker can recreate; only Life can restore the mortal to incorruption (*On the Incarnation* 4–10, 20, 54). Ontology opens into salvation without becoming identical with it. Natural existence is gift; life in Christ is a further, supernatural participation by grace.

8.2 Love returning to Love

Created love cannot equal its source. It can receive and answer. St. Bernard of Clairvaux describes the Bride's love as returning to its principle: the little stream cannot match the fountain, yet what flows back was first received from the fountain (*Sermons on the Song of Songs* 83.3–6). St. John of the Cross presses the mystery into Trinitarian participation: in union by grace the soul loves God with the love God communicates, without ceasing to be a creature (*Spiritual Canticle*, stanza 39.4–6, second redaction).

This is neither absorption nor equality of essence. The distinction established by creation remains forever. Grace does not make the creature uncreated; it gives a created participation in divine life (2 Pet 1:4). The more completely the creature receives, the more completely it becomes itself. Union is not erasure but communion.

John tests contemplation by love of the brother. Whoever claims to love the unseen God while refusing the neighbor contradicts the revealed form of participation (1 John 4:20–21). Augustine makes the same movement in *De Trinitate* VIII and his homilies on First John: charity turns the heart toward invisible God precisely by taking visible form in mercy and righteousness. Mysticism that ends in fascination with one's own interior state has not reached the Johannine summit.

The creature's answer is therefore both ecstatic and ordinary. To receive another person's being as gift; to will the true good rather than consume; to forgive without calling evil good; to praise without possessing; to let truth purify desire—these are finite acts, enabled and elevated by grace, in which received love returns toward unreceived Love.

The metaphysical feeling has become moral. If my existence is gift, I cannot treat another received existence as raw material for my will. If divine love creates goodness rather than feeding upon it, created love approaches its source by giving, guarding, and serving the good it did not originate.

9 The Last Word

Return once more to the ordinary room. The table, the wall, the moving hand have not become less real because they are dependent. They have become more astonishing. Their solidity is not self-explanation. Their contingency is not emptiness. Each stands in its own nature because the uncreated source gives it an act of being that is really its own and never self-originated.

Trace the ascent once more. Change points beyond potency to act, borrowed causal power to an underived source, received existence to subsistent being itself. Composition yields to simplicity and possible first principles to the unity of pure act. Creation from nothing is seen as present conservation; transcendence makes possible an intimacy deeper than place; knowledge rises until light is dark from excess.

Then reason stops honestly. It has not failed. It has reached its natural shore. It knows that the source is one, uncreated, intelligent, free, good, and loving; it does not know by its own power that the One is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. It cannot convert the structure of an argument into a divine self-revelation.

Across that boundary comes not a deduction but a Word. The Word is with God and is God; all things are made through him. The Word becomes flesh. The Father sends the Son. The Spirit is given. The eternal communion hidden

from the unaided ascent enters history, touches wounds, bears death, and opens created persons to a participation no metaphysical nature could demand.

The first Cause is thus not less personal than the minds he causes. The simplicity of God is not a frozen emptiness. The unity of God is not solitary arithmetic. The immutability of God is not indifference. The darkness is not vacancy. At the root of every created act is unreceived Act; within the life of the unreceived One, revelation discloses eternal Word and proceeding Love.

There is no further cause behind God, no deeper principle that explains why he is. His essence is his existence. There is also no need behind creation, as though a defect compelled him to make. The particular counsels of Providence remain hidden, and “love” must never be used to pretend we can decode every suffering. Yet the most universal truth about the creature’s existence is gift: it is freely willed by the One whose love does not take goodness from things but gives goodness to them.

This is the existential reversal. At first the regress seemed to strip the world of support. In truth it strips away imaginary independence. The abyss beneath creatures is not another layer of matter, an impersonal law, or an infinite postponement. It is the uncreated plenitude by whose will there are creatures at all. The mind looking for a final explanation finds that it is itself already known, already caused, already held.

And faith hears the name of that plenitude not in a theorem but in the apostolic witness to Father, Son, Spirit, and Cross. The phrase is small enough to memorize and inexhaustible enough to contain the rest of one’s life. It does not abolish the metaphysical ascent. It reveals why the ascent ends in adoration.

God is love.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and method

This is a discursive metaphysical and spiritual-theological article for a serious general reader. It asks what kind of ultimate source is required by changing, caused, and participated being, what existential posture follows from that dependence, and how Christian revelation transforms the ascent without being reduced to its final philosophical step.

The argument is deliberately Thomistic: it distinguishes a temporal series from present essentially ordered dependence; moves through act and potency, essence and existence, divine simplicity and unity, creation and conservation, participation and analogical naming; and states exactly where natural reason ends. The patristic and mystical witnesses do not function as a vote or as substitutes for demonstration. They show Christian reception, apophatic discipline, and the conversion of metaphysical judgment into wonder, desire, and charity.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Sacred Scripture	Inspired and normative witness to creation through the Word, the revealed divine name, Trinitarian mission, and “God is love.”	The article’s metaphysical synthesis is not attributed to the human author of one proof-text; short English phrases are working renderings.
Conciliar and catechetical teaching	Governs one Creator, creation from nothing and in freedom, simplicity, Trinity, and the truth that God’s very being is Love.	Document and locus control; authoritative synthesis is not flattened into a philosophical demonstration.
Patristic witness	Supplies creation through the Word, apophatic restraint, contemplative ascent, and Trinitarian reading of charity.	A Father may illuminate without every image becoming a definition or unanimous patristic formula.
Thomistic theology	Provides the article’s principal metaphysical grammar and its explicit natural-reason / revelation boundary.	The synthesis is identified as Thomistic where Catholic doctrine does not require this exact philosophical articulation.
Mystical witness	Shows received being and charity becoming contemplative desire and participatory love.	No literary image is a promise of sensible experience, private revelation, absorption, or equality of essence.
Project synthesis	Orders the “metaphysical vertigo,” mirror, room, shore, and ascent imagery into a reader-facing movement.	These images are original editorial synthesis, not quotations or experiences attributed to a source.

A.2 Included and excluded scope

Included are the relevant contours of Aquinas’s first two ways; the essence–existence and participation arguments; divine simplicity, unity, presence, creation, and conservation; the analogical attribution of love to God; the natural unknowability of the Trinity; the revealed processions of Word and Love; and a bounded patristic and mystical reception in Athanasius, Gregory Nazianzen, Augustine, Pseudo-Dionysius, Bernard, and John of the Cross.

Excluded are a comprehensive defense of every premise in classical theism; modern analytic reconstructions and objections; scientific cosmology; the Kalam argument; the complete doctrine of divine ideas, providence, evil, grace, deification, or the beatific vision; East–West disputes over Trinitarian procession; and a history of apophatic or mystical theology. The article neither proves a first temporal instant nor claims that a philosophical demonstration compels the mystery of the Trinity.

The phrase “God is love” is correctly attributed to 1 John 4:8 and 4:16, not to the Gospel of John. The Gospel’s Prologue and John 17 provide the Johannine account of the eternal Word and the Father’s love for the Son; the First Letter supplies the exact confession within the missions of Son and Spirit and the command to love one another.

A.3 Material qualifications

1. “First” is metaphysical, not necessarily chronological. Aquinas holds the temporal beginning of creation by faith while denying that reason demonstrates it (ST I, q. 46, a. 2).
2. The article does not argue that “everything has a cause.” It argues from actualized potency, derivative causal power, and participated existence; pure act and subsistent being are not members of the received class.
3. *Ipsū esse subsistens* is Thomistic metaphysical language. The article notes a traditional consonance with Exodus 3:14 but does not turn the Hebrew verse into a scholastic proof.
4. Creation *ex nihilo* does not make “nothing” a material and does not mean an emanation of divine substance. Creatures are really distinct from God and continuously dependent upon him.
5. Natural reason can attribute love to God analogically. It cannot demonstrate the three divine Persons or the full Trinitarian and Paschal content of 1 John 4.
6. “God is love” neither reverses into “every love is God” nor identifies human emotion with divine essence. In the simple God, love is without passion, need, acquisition, or change.
7. Augustine’s lover–beloved–love triad is used as a contemplative starting point under revelation, not as a natural proof or literal diagram of the Trinity.
8. Pseudo-Dionysian darkness means excess beyond finite comprehension, not evil, divine absence, irrationalism, or a technique guaranteed to produce experience.
9. Participation by grace never means absorption into the divine essence. The creature remains creature; union perfects rather than abolishes the created distinction.
10. The article’s universal claim that created being is freely willed does not claim knowledge of God’s particular providential reasons for every event, still less call moral evil good.

A.4 Translations, rights, currentness, and review

Scriptural wording is limited to short traditional or working-English phrases checked at the cited loci; no extended modern Bible translation is reproduced. Patristic English witnesses used for checking are the identified public-domain NPNF and nineteenth- or early-twentieth-century editions. Thomas is cited principally by stable work, question, article, chapter, and paragraph rather than by dependence upon one English wording. The brief Latin and English formulas remain source material outside the project’s CC BY 4.0 license; the surrounding synthesis is project-created.

Online witnesses and source loci were checked through 20 July 2026. No mutable discipline, jurisdiction-specific rule, or current legal conclusion governs this article. The publication is an internally source-audited working study. It has not received independent philosophical, patristic, Thomistic, mystical-theological, dogmatic, or ecclesiastical review and claims no ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Sacred Scripture

- Gen 1:1; Exod 3:1–15; Deut 6:4; Wis 11:24–26, 13:1–9; 2 Macc 7:28; John 1:1–3, 14, 18, 17:20–26; Acts 17:24–28; Rom 1:19–20, 5:5, 11:33–36; Eph 3:14–21; Heb 1:1–3; 2 Pet 1:4; 1 John 1:5, 4:7–21.
- “God is love” is the concise traditional English rendering of 1 John 4:8 and 4:16, read in the complete 4:7–16 unit. The article does not reproduce an extended modern translation.

Councils and authoritative synthesis

- Fourth Lateran Council, *Firmiter credimus* (1215), DS 800–802: one, simple Trinitarian God, Creator of visible and invisible things from nothing; the distinction of Persons does not divide the essence. The compact English citation in CCC 202 is governed by the conciliar text.
- First Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Dei Filius* (1870), ch. 1 and canons 1.1–5, DS 3001–3003, 3021–3025: one true, living, simple God; free creation of all things from nothing, distinct from the divine substance and ordered to divine goodness; official Latin text.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, nos. 198–231, especially 202–213 and 221 (one God, the revealed name, received being, truth, and love), official English; nos. 232–267 (Trinity); 279–301 (creation from nothing, freedom, the Word, and divine goodness).

- *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, nos. 464–469, especially 468–469 (the one divine Person of the Son as subject of the acts and sufferings of his assumed human nature, without confusion or change), official English.

Patristic and late-patristic witnesses

- St. Athanasius of Alexandria, *On the Incarnation of the Word* 3–5, 20, 42, 54, on creation from nothing through the good God’s Word, present dependence, Incarnation, and renewal; NPNF working English. *Orations Against the Arians* I.14, 19, on the eternal, uncreated Word proper to the Father; working English.
- St. Gregory Nazianzen, *Oration* 28.4–6, on knowing that God is while failing to comprehend the divine nature, working English; *Oration* 45.3, on God as beyond time and creaturely comprehension, drawing through wonder and desire, working English.
- St. Augustine of Hippo, *Confessions* III.6.11; VII.10.16–11.17; XI.5.7–9.11, on divine inwardness and transcendence, the unchangeable Light, creaturely participation, creation in the Word, dread, and desire; Book III, Book VII, Book XI.
- Augustine, *De Trinitate* VIII.2.3–3.5 and VIII.7.10–10.14, on mutable goods, Good itself, true charity, and lover–beloved–love as a beginning of Trinitarian inquiry, working English; XV.17.27–18.32, on Gift and Love, working English; *Homilies on the First Epistle of John* VII.9–10, on the unseen God and visible works of charity, working English.
- Pseudo-Dionysius, *Divine Names* IV.1, 7, 10, 13, on the Good as cause and end and on love’s unitive motion; *Mystical Theology* I.1–3 and II.1, on affirmation, negation, and luminous unknowing. Checked in John Parker, trans., *The Works of Dionysius the Areopagite*, vol. 1 (London: James Parker, 1897), public-domain working edition. The author is identified according to modern convention rather than equated with the convert of Acts 17.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 2, aa. 1–3 (demonstration from effects, act and potency, ordered movers and causes, contingency); q. 3, especially aa. 1–5, 7–8 (pure act, essence and existence, simplicity, and exclusion from a genus); q. 4, aa. 2–3 (subsistent being and creaturely likeness); qq. 5–6 (being and goodness, participated goodness); q. 8, aa. 1, 3 (intimate causal presence); q. 11, aa. 3–4 (divine unity); q. 13, aa. 4–5, 11 (analogical names and “He Who Is”).
- Aquinas, ST I, q. 19, aa. 2–4 (God’s goodness, free willing of creatures, and non-necessity of creation); q. 20, aa. 1–2 (love in God and divine love as the cause of created goodness); q. 27, aa. 1–4 (processions of Word and Love); q. 29, a. 4 (divine Persons as subsistent relations); q. 32, a. 1 (Trinity not demonstrable by natural reason); q. 34, aa. 1–2 (Word); q. 37, aa. 1–2 (Love as essential and personal name); q. 43, aa. 1–2 (missions and eternal processions); q. 44, aa. 1–4 (universal causality and participation); q. 45, aa. 1–3, 5–7 (creation, nothing, and the Trinity); q. 46, a. 2 (temporal beginning not demonstrated); q. 104, a. 1 (conservation as continued causation of being).
- Aquinas, *De ente et essentia*, ch. 4, on caused existence and the first cause whose essence is existence; *Summa contra Gentiles* I.13, 16, 22, 37–40, 81, 91, and II.15–17, 21, 23, for fuller parallel arguments.
- Latin loci checked in the Corpus Thomisticum Leonine-text corpus; New Advent used as a working public English index. Citations by work, question, article, and chapter govern over either site’s wording.

Mystical and monastic witnesses

- St. Bernard of Clairvaux, *Sermons on the Song of Songs* 83.3–6, on love returning to its divine source and receiving from the fountain the power to answer. Latin checked in *Sancti Bernardi Opera*, vol. 2, 300–302, with online Latin witness; Samuel J. Eales’s 1895 English used only as a public-domain working aid.
- St. John of the Cross, *Spiritual Canticle*, stanza 39.4–6, second redaction, on created participation by grace in Trinitarian love. Checked in David Lewis, trans., Benedict Zimmerman, rev. (1909), public-domain working edition; stanza numbering and redaction are identified because editions differ.

C Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-20T18:51:11Z

Model: GPT-5-based Codex agent; **unexposed:** exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (patristic and Thomistic source research, source audit, drafting, typesetting, and visual QA roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

Reuse and rights. To the extent Triptych holds the rights, project-created content and design are licensed under CC BY 4.0. Scripture, liturgical or official texts, received prayers or hymns, quotations, fonts, and other third-party material retain their own status; public-domain material remains public domain. Identify changes. Attribution implies neither Triptych nor ecclesiastical approval. See **LICENSE** and **THIRD_PARTY.md** in the source.